in Coimbatore fizzled out with his massive defeat to the DMK's Ganapathy P. Rajkumar by over 118,000 votes. Former AIADMK chief minister O. Panneerselvam's candidacy as an NDA-backed Independent in Ramanathapuram also came a cropper.

"A coherent Dravidian identity narrative, state autonomy plank and the grassroots organisational prowess helped the DMK secure its fortress," says political analyst Ramu Manivannan. Making the DMK's triumph even more remarkable is the fact that for the first time since 1967 a ruling party-led alliance has achieved a clean sweep in the state, the previous such feats a preserve of the Opposition benches. DMK insiders attribute it to sustained alliance cohesion since 2019 and meticulous constituency-level efforts. Its ally Congress reaped rich dividends, with all nine candidates, including former bureaucrat Sasikanth Senthil (Thiruvallur), getting a ticket to the Lok Sabha.



ANI

▲ **THE DECISIVE HAND** Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin addressing a gathering, Apr. 18

THE AGENDA AHEAD

With the legislative assembly election just two years away, the BJP's hopes of forging its own alliance, without having to piggyback on Dravidian majors, have receded with this Lok Sabha election. One silver lining could be its vote share nearly tripling and reaching double digits from 2019's 3.7 per cent to 11.2 per cent. That, though, is more due to the BJP contesting 23 seats, up from five in the previous election. The AIADMK, too, seems ill-prepared for the 2026 assembly hustings. "The BJP's conscious strategy has enfeebled the AIADMK. Internal criticism is inevitable, but with the defeat of breakaway leaders T.T.V. Dhinakaran and O. Panneerselvam (OPS), Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS, the Opposition leader) remains a force to reckon with," Manivannan says.

The prospect of the BJP reworking its strategy and extending a hand to the AIADMK remains. "Teaming up didn't pay dividends in the past, but the temptation to jointly stir up any anti-incumbency sentiment against the DMK regime may persist," says Chennai-based political commentator N. Sathia Moorthy. To expand in Tamil Nadu, the BJP will have to considerably temper its Hindutva pitch, counter perceptions of being anti-South and, most importantly, says Moorthy, authenticate its embrace of Tamil culture beyond tokenisms like "brandishing the Sengol".

That said, the DMK too has to brace for more battles with the Centre as it will now have to deal with a more aggressive governor in R.N. Ravi, who has stalled legislations and stirred controversies over the customary addresses to the legislative assembly. This gubernatorial friction aside, financial devolution, delimitation and inter-state river disputes loom as other flashpoints. ■